

GNU Cash

How many of you have asked yourselves the question “Where does my money go?” every month-end? We don’t realise how much we’re spending until the wallet is empty. For example, if you planned to buy something big and were saving for it, you get a reality check at the month-end—you weren’t actually saving, because your money has to go towards your credit card bill! This is why we need financial planning—to prioritise our needs and track expenditure and savings. The GNU Cash financial accounting software is one open source tool which does just that. GNU Cash can help both individuals and organisations, allowing you to track bank accounts, stocks, income and expenses—while even assisting you to actually save money.

You can download the latest release from <http://www.gnucash.org>. It’s available for almost all common OSs, including GNU/Linux, BSD, Solaris, Mac OS X and MS Windows. Installation is pretty simple: *Next, Next, Finish*. When you launch it, you get a window titled ‘Unsaved book’. Go to *File->New File* for a window to set up a new account; from here, you can create accounts for assets, liabilities, etc. Once you select your currency, you can select the categories to add in your account; each category has a set of accounts. Select the categories suiting your needs. You can always add accounts later. Now you can save the account as a file (which is good for individuals) or to a database. A file is good if you’re not sure about databases. Now you’re ready to go! Remember to update your account regularly to track daily expenses and savings. You can view reports under the Reports link.

There is a lot more to GNU Cash; you can use it for small businesses too, with the provision to manage invoices, vendors, employees, customers, etc. Hope this introduction sparked your interest in this tool. Happy saving!

Umllet

College students, software professionals or any one of us often need to draw a diagram to express an idea, design or concept. After all, a picture is worth a thousand words, and is the best way to convey your thoughts. If you’ve ever tried to draw a diagram using MS Word, you probably know it’s better to write out those thousand words instead. Well, sarcasm apart, here is an easy-to-use open source diagramming tool: Umllet, the free UML tool. Download the zip file from <http://www.umllet.com>. Unzip it to get the .exe and .jar files; run either to get started. The .jar file can run on any platform with Java 1.6+ installed. When you open Umllet, you get a window divided in three parts. On the left is your drawing canvas, the upper right half has the default drawing elements, and the lower right is the *Properties* pane. You can drag and drop elements to the canvas to draw your diagram. Resize the elements directly on the canvas, and change text using the *Properties* pane.

You can easily add new elements via the custom elements link, which offers a graphical as well as code interface to create custom elements.

You can copy diagrams and paste to other documents, or also mail them directly. The tool is highly configurable, and in case of a doubt check <http://www.umllet.com/faq.htm>.

Audacity

Audacity is an open source tool to record and edit sounds. It has features for converting tapes and LPs to digital recordings, and recording streaming audio playing on the computer. It offers a lot to general-purpose users: music capture, converting favourite tunes to mobile ring-tones and more. Download it from <http://audacity.sourceforge.net/download/>. The current release 1.3.14 is a beta; the stable release 1.2.6 doesn’t support Windows XP/Vista. Choose which one you want and install it.

To edit sound clips, open them via *File -> Open* to get a graphical representation of the clip. Now select the part to edit. You can add various effects (the *Effect* menu). More professional users can add effects manually using the Draw tool and the other tools available.

To record sounds, select the proper input device and click the record button; then save it to the desired file format. This tool has various other features you can put to good use.

Winmerge

Winmerge is an open source graphical tool to compare files/folders and merge differences. Currently available for Windows, it will soon be available for other platforms. Get it from <http://winmerge.org/downloads/>. After installation, you can open files or folders to compare them. Comparing folders will show up files that differ; for files, the view shows the differences in yellow, by default. A few icons at the top are very useful, especially for bigger files. The ‘*Next Difference*’ and ‘*Previous Difference*’ buttons visit the next/previous differences found, eliminating the chance of missing one while manually scrolling. Other features are self-explanatory.

To merge differences, you can use the ‘*Copy Right*’ or ‘*Copy Left*’ button. The *Copy* and *Advance* button merges and moves to the next difference, in one go. As of now, Winmerge supports Windows, UNIX and Mac text file formats, and is usable for code and other text files.

So that’s it. Hope you liked the compilation and it inspires you to use these tools—or even better, get involved in the open source movement! All queries and feedback are welcome. 

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